

The Gates of Paradise

The Renaissance developed initially in Florence, Italy. At the time, the city was ruled by the wealthy Medici family, powerful bankers who became great patrons of the arts, commissioning works from Florence's leading artists. Cosimo (1389–1464) and Lorenzo de' Medici (1449–92) were two of the most influential members of the dynasty, and helped to establish Florence as a cultural centre. Ideas and art that emerged there then spread to other parts of Italy and Europe.

In 1401, a competition was held to design two massive bronze doors for the Baptistery in Florence. Finalists included Lorenzo Ghiberti (1419–52), Brunelleschi, Donatello and Jacopo della Quercia (c.1374–1438). Ghiberti's was the winning design, and he completed the doors 21 years later. The 28 panels, mainly depicting the life of Christ, earned him a further commission to create two further doors, featuring Old Testament images across ten panels. All feature the principles of perspective, creating a sense of depth. Michelangelo later nicknamed the doors 'the Gates of Paradise.'



Ghiberti, Porta del Paradiso of the Baptistry in Florence, 1422